

I'm too old for this shit!

I'm quoting Danny Glover's character from the *Lethal Weapon* series of movies, of course. I quote him because this issue is somewhat of a milestone for me. It's the 150th issue of Digit that I've contributed to – starting as a trainee copy editor, back in January 2003.

It's crazy, the sheer amount of people I've had the privilege of working with for Digit in those twelve and a half years! I can't even remember the names of some of them, but then I'm terrible with names anyway. Before anything else, I just want to take the opportunity to thank everyone who worked with me (and put up with me) for any of those 150 issues. You're all truly special.

In the last 150 months, I've seen technology truly metamorphose from something niche that only a few of us geeks used, to something the world just accepts as commonplace now. From a time when students used to be just kids, to present day when some kids these days already have titles of CEO! Technology has truly enabled India.

Another reason for the headline is because at Digit, we've always had brilliant but lazy people. From guys who could code a CMS if you dared them to (before CMSes were commonplace) to gamers and misfits, we've had them all. We've also had the most interesting conversations here, especially during issue closing, when we'd spend days (weeks?) in office. Very often, those conversations would be about ideas that should be implemented in the technology world. Never once did it occur to us to go ahead and try to turn those ideas into reality ourselves, sadly. Every single current and ex Digit employee will testify to this...the sheer amount of ideas that a group of creative people can come up with is staggering.

I still remember wanting to build a software (app?) in 2004 that would help you recognise a song you heard, just by humming it – because you didn't know the name or the lyrics, just the tune. This was back when music was worth hunting for, not the artificially created tripe people listen to because the artists are "cute". Yes Beliebers and One Direction lovers, I mean you! Anyway, SoundHound kind of does that, though I think it would have been way more successful back in 2004 when I first thought of it, because people actually needed it more back then.

Twitter? We discussed something similar over pizza when stuck in office during the famous 26/7 Mumbai rains in 2005. Oh, and I remember hating the idea then, and I still do – billions of dollars or not!

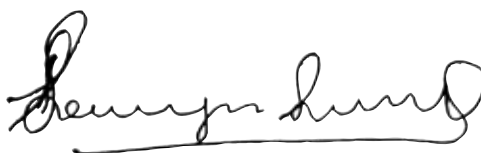
We also discussed all-touch devices about six months before the iPhone was launched. I remember that someone (can't remember who) put up an impassioned debate as to why touch was the future, because of the LG Prada and some Samsung model (but better software was needed). Being an old school Palm Zire user, I loved touch, and especially Palm's software implementation, so I argued on behalf of touch that day. Then six months later, the iPhone launched, became insanely popular, and proved that hypothesis correct as well.

There are so many more times this happened, but it's pointless to try and remember all of them. Besides, you get the basic idea, right? The point is that although many creative Indians might have had ideas for products that could be a global success, we had a totally defeatist attitude towards everything back then. Perhaps with good reason, perhaps not, however it was what it was. I, for one, regret that of all the brilliant people who came and went through Digit, not one of us backed our ideas with faith and action.

Today, however, that opportunity exists in India. You can actually get millions of dollars of investment with an idea and a plan, because someone will fall in love with your vision (and the profits it can earn them). We know this based on all past success stories, which were missing back in the day.

You can have an idea, and then decide to follow through on it. You can, really, be your own boss in today's India. All you have to do is not give in to the defeatist attitude like we used to. And it doesn't matter how old you are either, so long as you have passion and belief, nothing else matters. Perhaps it's why, at least when it comes to Digit, I'm still able to tell myself, after all these years, "I'm *not* too old for this shit!"

Now go build something already! 




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